

How life began

Earth first formed about 4.6 billion years ago. When the planet was very young, life would have been impossible—the ground was blisteringly hot and there was no water in sight. So how did life begin?

EARLY EARTH

A sea of molten rock covered the newly formed Earth. In time, this cooled to solid rock, but volcanoes continued to spew out floods of lava. The volcanoes also released gases from deep inside the planet, forming Earth's atmosphere, though the air at first was poisonous.

COMETS AND ASTEROIDS

For millions of years, Earth's surface was bombarded by comets, asteroids, and even small planets. The collisions tore open the planet's newly formed crust, releasing more floods of lava. But they also delivered water.